

RESURRECTION PEOPLE, BUT FIRST?

This year when Lent began, we had expectations of how the season would go. We'd give up our chocolate or soft drinks and spend a little bit more time reading our Bibles and praying. During Holy Week, we'd wave palms and shout "hosanna," wash one another's feet on Thursday, hear the story of Jesus dying on the cross on Friday, then gather together on Easter Sunday to celebrate the empty tomb and our risen Savior.

However, Holy Week became really different really fast. Suddenly we had to give up more than soda; we sacrificed our routine and sense of normalcy to protect our neighbors. Adults have wrestled with technology while teens have struggled with balancing responsibility and escapism in their online habits. The loss of normalcy has brought uncertainty and loss. Canceled graduations, proms, sports meets, vacations, and mission trips scratch only the surface for those whose families have also lost income or stability. What we have known as normal has died.

Grieving During Eastertide

The season of Eastertide runs from Easter Sunday to Pentecost, observed on May 31 this year, and is typically a time of celebration. While there are still worthy celebrations this Eastertide, it may be more difficult knowing that even by the end of the season life still may not be back to normal. So what do we do with our grief and our sadness during a season typically marked by celebration?

Death and Resurrection

Easter is one of the most significant moments in the Christian faith. Jesus, fully divine and fully human, died a real death and was buried in a real tomb—but he didn't stay there for long. The good news of the gospel is this: God is more powerful than all things, even the ultimate physical distancing measure of death. The God we worship is all about making new things out of dust, like a phoenix rising from its ashes. While this is good news for our future, the reality can feel really dim. Scripture tells us the stories of many people, including Jesus, who encountered death and grief.

TIP FOR THIS ISSUE

We're talking about death today, and it's important to note that not all of our teens have experienced the death of a loved one. On the other hand, some may have encountered more death than an average adult. This session can be a great opportunity to invite students and their parents to talk together about mortality within a Christian framework.

Be cautious using language that reinforces the idea that God is OK with people dying or ordains their death at a certain time. We worship a God of love who calls us into a life a wholeness.



FACING UNCERTAINTY

Question of the Day: How are you honest with God?

Purpose: To talk about grief and loss.

Cultural Connection: Coronavirus and Easter

Topic: Death and Resurrection

JOB LAYS IT OUT TO GOD

Job 7:1-12

So I have inherited months of emptiness; nights of toil have been measured out for me. If I lie down and think—when will I get up?—night drags on, and restless thoughts fill me until dawn. —Job 7:3-4

Commentary:

The Book of Job is an interesting one. Likely written during the Exile, the author tells the story of a most pious man, Job, who lived with integrity and “avoided evil” (Job 1:1). While doing his own thing, God and the Adversary have a discussion about humankind; in particular they discuss Job’s commitment to God. Would Job still be loyal to God if he no longer had wealth, stability, and good health? The Adversary sets out to discover the answer.

When we pick up the story in chapter 7, the Adversary has taken away Job’s farm, his sons and daughters, and has afflicted Job with sores from head to toe. His wife has pleaded with him to appease God, and his friends have visited to see if they can help. They all want Job to apologize to God, assuming that Job is at fault for the madness. Instead, Job gets angry with God. In chapter 7, he doesn’t hold back and honestly describes his feelings. He accuses God of being confused, of antagonizing him, and for what? He has been nothing but loyal, so why does God see fit to treat Job this way?

Questions to think about:

- ▶ When was the last time you were angry with God?
- ▶ What does Job’s anger say about his faith?

LAZARUS IS RAISED

John 11:1-45

When Martha heard that Jesus was coming, she went to meet him . . . Martha said to Jesus, “Lord, if you had been here, my brother wouldn’t have died.” —John 11:20-21



Commentary:

Jesus knew that Lazarus was sick; and his sisters, Mary and Martha, knew Jesus could heal him. But Jesus chose to stay where he was so, by the time he reached the siblings, his friend Lazarus had died. Understandably so, Martha was upset with Jesus. He could heal people, sure, but death is more permanent. The sisters lead Jesus to the tomb where Lazarus is buried, and the narrator is quite clear that he is truly dead. Jesus stands at the entry and cries.

Even for Jesus and the disciples, there was this period of helplessness. Idle time—when the reality of loss feels so heavy and so final—and crying is the easiest outlet for all the disappointment and ache inside. We don’t know how long Jesus stood there weeping for his friend but, after a while, he turns to God and asks for a miracle.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ With whom do you most identify in this passage, and why?
- ▶ How are you still waiting for God to show up in your life?

THE ROAD TO EMMAUS

Luke 24:13-35

He said to them, “What are you talking about as you walk along?” They stopped, their faces downcast. The one named Cleopas replied, “Are you the only visitor to Jerusalem who is unaware of the things that have taken place there over the last few days?” —Luke 24:17-18

Commentary:

The same day his tomb is discovered empty, Jesus makes several appearances to his disciples. In this story, he

TEACHER BIBLE PREP



approaches two of his disciples who were not part of the eleven but had clearly spent time with the Teacher. Over the course of seven days, their entire world had changed from waving branches to hurling accusations as they witnessed the person they called Lord hang on a cross and die. No wonder their faces were downcast!

The disciples faced great uncertainty in the days ahead, and they took advantage of the long walk ahead of them to process the previous week's events. Jesus walks along with them and, in their confusion and anxiety, he spells out a message of hope, ultimately breaking bread and revealing himself as the risen Christ.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ If Jesus went on a walk with you today, what would you want to talk about?
- ▶ What is God revealing to you in this section of the journey?

.....

DEVOTION: COMFORT IN THE ASHES

By the end of the book, Job has experienced extreme loss. His family has died, his farm has been destroyed, and his friends ended up being complete hot heads. Throughout the story, Job is blunt in his conversations with God and, after a lengthy response from the Divine, he realizes his human limitations. Read Job 42:1-6:

Job answered the LORD:

I know you can do anything;

no plan of yours can be opposed successfully.

You said, "Who is this darkening counsel without knowledge?"

I have indeed spoken about things I didn't understand, wonders beyond my comprehension.

You said, "Listen and I will speak;

I will question you and you will inform me."

My ears had heard about you,

but now my eyes have seen you.

Therefore, I relent and find comfort on dust and ashes.

Think of the last time you touched ashes, maybe at a campfire or leftover from grilling. Close your eyes and imagine their feel between your fingers, the way it smelled, the way it looked. Now, take a deep breath and let it out



If Jesus went on a walk with you today, what would you want to talk about?

slowly. Where do the ashes go? Ash is uncomfortable and can irritate sensitive skin. Ash is the remains of something that has been consumed by fire.

If Job's faith was a house, it was burned to the ground, leaving only the foundation standing. In verse 5, he acknowledges a shift from *knowing about* God to *knowing God* for himself. He finds comfort in the ashes, recognizing life is hard now but that God, infinite in power and mercy, will ultimately bring about goodness.

NEXT WEEK: Confinement does weird things to people, and we're all responding differently to our new realities. Next week in LINC we'll talk about the incredible outpouring from the artistic community during this time and the new ways artists are finding to connect with the world.

LINC: Living in Christ is an official resource of The United Methodist Church approved by Discipleship Ministries and published by Youth Ministry Partners and Cokesbury: The United Methodist Publishing House, 2222 Rosa L. Parks Blvd., Nashville, TN 37228-1306.

Scripture quotations unless noted otherwise are taken from the Common English Bible, copyright 2011. Used by permission. All rights reserved.

Available by e-mail subscription by calling toll free: 800-672-1789. Also available for download from:

`frnq8--uuu,amicq`spw,amk-jgla=n_eclsk`cp;/`

Writer: Audrua Malvaez

Editor: Kevin Alton

Production Editor: Pam Shepherd

Template Designer: Micah Kandros

JESUS CAN HANDLE IT



Getting Ready: This lesson can be led virtually via whatever software your ministry is using, or it can be held within the family unit at home. Students will need access to Holy Listening Stones at https://12e41b98-00b1-3f1b-7046-faddbd3fa824.filesusr.com/ugd/221cbf_7aef639b49d94d909ee5df8622722c40.pdf (for more on Holy Listening Stones, see <https://www.leanne-hadley.com/holy-listening>); blank paper or a word processing app; access to YouTube; pens or pencils, and a snack. If possible, email copies of Youth Page 6 to your students ahead of time.

OPEN Fingers (10 minutes)

Begin your time together by playing a round of First to Ten. Each person begins with all ten fingers down on their hands. As you call out each item from the list below, instruct students to put up a finger if it applies to them. First person with all ten fingers up wins!

List for play:

- watched the complete speech of a world leader
- someone sprayed you with antiseptic
- scrolled through memes for an hour
- watched someone else's church online
- created your own meme
- skipped bathing/showering for a whole 24 hours
- didn't brush your teeth for a day
- wore the same pajamas for three days straight
- cooked dinner for your family
- baked a dessert
- found a book or toy from childhood and read/played with it
- organized your closet
- made a Tik Tok
- cried/threw a book over e-learning
- called your grandparents
- read your Bible



EXPLORE

Talk Topic 1: God Can Handle Our Anger (15 minutes)

Middle School Option

Make sure everyone has a copy of or access to the Holy Listening Stones at https://12e41b98-00b1-3f1b-7046-faddbd3fa824.filesusr.com/ugd/221cbf_7aef639b49d94d909ee5df8622722c40.pdf. Ask students what they know about Job. Fill in any necessary details, then call on several volunteers to take turns reading aloud Job 7:1-21 as dramatically as possible.

Invite students to read the Scripture through again silently, then choose three listening stones from the visual to describe Job's feelings. Ask students to tell the stones they selected and what they represent to them. Say: "Job was bold to lay out his frustrations with God so directly. What if God had been insulted? Wouldn't that make God even more angry?" Ask:

▶ How do you think God felt hearing Job's anger and hurt?

Remind students that God is not indifferent to our pain. Invite students to tell what the last few weeks have been like for them. When the conversation slows, ask students to select three listening stones that represent their personal feelings. Call on volunteers to tell their chosen stones and the reasons why they selected each one.

High School Option

Begin by telling about a loss you have experienced as a result of the pandemic, then ask students to tell about their losses. Transition by introducing the story of Job, a man who experienced a lot of loss in a short amount of time. Call on volunteers to read aloud Job 7:1-21, then ask:

▶ What is Job saying to God?

▶ Job is described as being the most faithful follower of God, so we can assume he knew God's character. How would you describe God's character?

Say: "God is love, but Job didn't feel loved. He was honest and told God how awful he was feeling." Ask:

▶ Are there any phrases Job uses that you could see yourself saying to God?

▶ How do you usually handle your anger and stress?

Make sure each student has a device for writing, digital or paper and pens or pencils. Ask them to write a letter to God expressing their feelings with a vulnerability similar to Job's.

**God is love, but Job didn't feel loved.
He was honest and told God how awful he was feeling.**

JESUS CAN HANDLE IT

The disciples had been eating dinner with Jesus for years.
This time was different.



Talk Topic 2: Take a Minute (15 minutes)

Middle School Option

If you are meeting via video call, invite parents to join for this segment. Watch this video together of John 11:1-45 at <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Dca8SSxXCmM>. Alternately, divide the reading into segments and ask parents to read aloud the story. When finished, summarize the commentary in Teacher Bible Prep and ask:

- ▶ What does it feel like to lose a good friend (not necessarily to death)?
- ▶ Is there anything about this story that bothers you?

Invite parents to share with their student about the death of a loved one using these prompts:

- When I heard the news, I felt . . .
- In the days immediately following, it was hard to . . .
- I handled the grief by . . .

High School Option

Lead a virtual readers theater with students, assigning parts for narrator, disciples, the crowd, Jesus, Mary, and Martha. Ensure everyone knows their part, then read aloud together John 11:1-45.

Lead a discussion around these questions:

- ▶ Where do you see yourself in the story? What character's experience best relates to your own?
- ▶ What details would you add to the story from your point of view?

Say: "Much like Mary and Martha, we are in a waiting period. We don't know when life will return to normal or what normal will look like. Jesus meets us like he met the sisters." Transition by asking, "What would you say to Jesus if he walked into your house today?"

BONUS SMALL GROUP DISCUSSION

Participate in the ancient practice of *visio divina* using this video from *A Sanctified Art* at <https://vimeo.com/400079553>. If you're

able, share your screen with the group so everyone can see it at the same time. After watching, ask what stood out to students in both the visuals and the reading. Ask: "What about this experience was new for you? How did you feel while the video was playing?"

Talk Topic 3: Eating Dinner with Jesus (15 minutes)

Middle School Option

Invite students to tell about their Easter experience this year and how it was different from normal. Say: "The disciples who followed Jesus had been celebrating Passover with their families for years. The first Easter felt a lot different to them because as far as they knew, the person they believed was the Son of God had died at the hands of the Roman Empire and an angry mob. It was an odd, uncertain, and different time for them."

Ask students to access or be ready to use Youth Page 6, as you show a copy on your screen. Read aloud Luke 24:13-35, then ask teens with electronic access to use the annotate feature and draw inside the circles six emojis that represent the disciples' experience on the road to Emmaus. Those with paper copies should do the same. When teens are finished, ask:

- ▶ Why did you choose those emojis?
- ▶ What can we learn about Jesus from this story?

High School Option

To begin, suggest each student get a snack (or a meal if it's meal time) and return to the gathering. Say: "Food was really important to Jesus. In fact, one of the two sacraments we practice in The United Methodist Church is all about a holy meal: Communion. Holy things happened around meals, including today's story." Read aloud Luke 42:13-35 and ask students to follow along in their Bibles, then ask:

- ▶ How have you seen God show up since the pandemic began in your community?
- ▶ How do you wish God would show up right now?

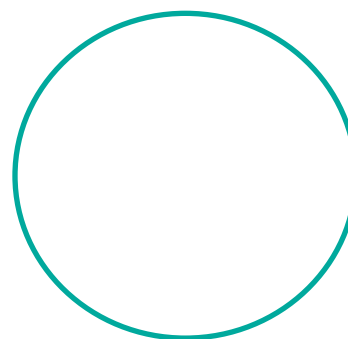
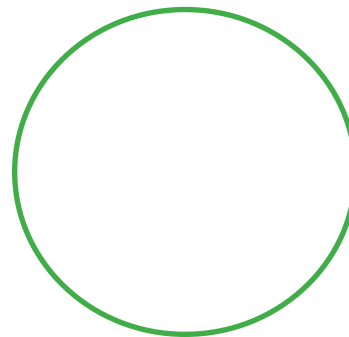
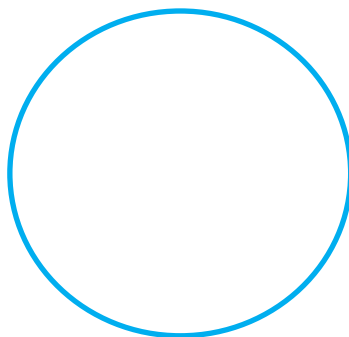
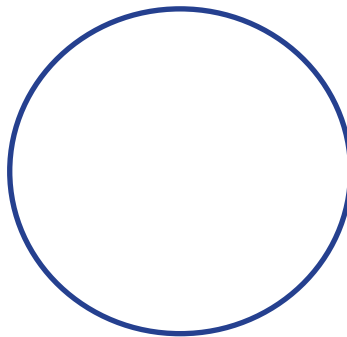
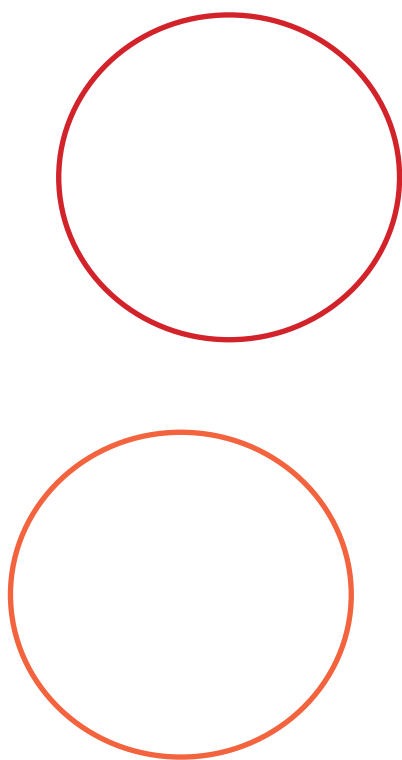
TAKE AWAY

As Christians, we are a resurrection people, but Scripture makes clear we can be a people of hope while also being honest about the pain we feel in our present reality.

WORKING IT OUT

THE ROAD TO EMMAUS

Draw inside the circles six emojis that represent the disciples' experience on the road to Emmaus.



In the Bible: Readings for the Week

MONDAY: Read Isaiah 40:12-31.

God will lift us up.

TUESDAY: Read 1 Corinthians 15:51-58.

Death has no hold on us.

WEDNESDAY: Read Exodus 12:14-17.

God has already started a new thing.

THURSDAY: Read Romans 8:26-28.

God works all things for good.

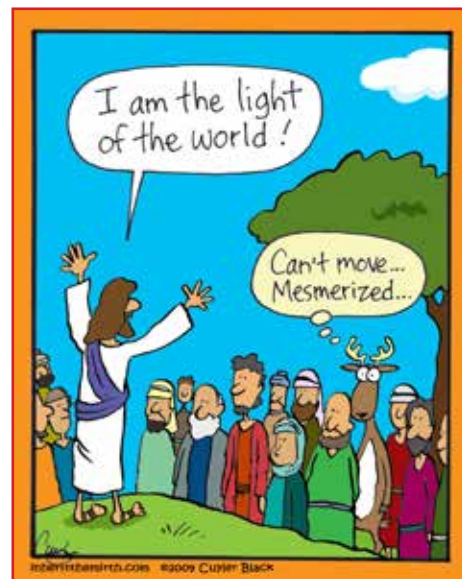
FRIDAY: Read Psalm 46.

God is our refuge.

SATURDAY: Read Lamentations 1:1-4.

The Israelites grapple with loss.

Inherit the Mirth



WHAT'S TRENDING?

What DID you do for Easter this year? Tweet or post your response with the hashtag #QuarantinedEaster on Twitter to @YMPartners or on facebook.com/youthministypartners